

Juggling Balls, Books, & Life

By Mallex Shipanga

When the crowd goes wild, Takudzwa Ambrose Mutengwa almost always stands at the centre of the excitement.

But behind the fanfare is a working student striving to excel in both academics, sport and work.

Mutengwa, born on 11 November 1999, grew up in Harare, the capital of Zimbabwe. There, he discovered his passion for basketball at an early age.

That passion was first sparked by hours spent watching his basketball idols compete in the American National Basketball Association (NBA). "Watching Allen Iverson and Kyrie Irving inspired me to play basketball from an early age," he said.

Mutengwa started playing basketball in 2011. Then a primary school boy, he quickly found himself drawn to local tournaments and school competitions, setting the stage for his journey as a student-athlete.

The small forward joined the Namibia University of Science and Technology (NUST) basketball team in 2019, where he is now a third-year informatics student.

"When I came to Namibia, I dove head first into computers because I've had a passion for computers for the longest time," he said.

Mutengwa represents NUST in the Khomas Basketball Association (KBA), Namibia's only competitive basketball league. This offers him a stage to test his talent against other top players nationwide.

"I continue to play in the KBA because it keeps me both physically and mentally fit," he said.

For Mutengwa, basketball is more than just a game.

"Basketball is like my first love. You get so many injuries from basketball, you get so many heartbreaks from basketball, but you still go back," he added.

In the life of a working student athlete, balancing academics, sport and work means meticulously managing your time.

Mutengwa described his daily routine in one word: "Hectic!"

He works as a system administrator at Katutura Hospital, one of Windhoek's busiest medical centres.

Twice a week, on Mondays and Wednesdays, he also works as a basketball coach, coaching secondary school players at St George's Diocesan School.

When the clock strikes 17h00, the part-time student turns into an academic weapon, learning about all things informatics.

Then, on Tuesdays and Thursdays, he shifts gears again, suiting up for practice at the NUST basketball court.

The game may end, but Mutengwa's journey is only beginning. For him, the NUST student-athlete experience is not only about chasing victories, it is about shaping the man he strives to become.

